

Black Americans, Iconic Barrier Breakers in 50+ Sports and Competitions

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Abstract

Born out of a tradition of segregated leagues, Black Americans broke barriers in over fifty sports and competitions. From Olympic podiums to boxing rings, rodeo arenas, tennis courts, and NASCAR tracks, champions exuded humility and class. A mystique formed around power salutes, stare-downs, confident struts, insider handshakes, and activism. Across six continents, taunts, groans, and jeers roared from the crowds. Flamed from survival, triumph, and freedom, a phenomenon unique to American soil, contenders displayed raw talent and iron will in a myriad of disciplines. Victories rarely translated into ownership, endorsement, or institutional power. Heroes existed, hidden in the footnotes of history, record books, and halls of fame. The research presents chronological evidence of international athletic dominance.

Introduction

Synergized with mental and physical strength, Black Americans challenged the world on level playing fields in dozens of events. Crowds witnessed "*David and Goliath*" spectacles. As athletic rivalries and empires soared, barrier-breaking performances dominated the newspapers.

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Track and Field: George Poage, the first Black runner to win an Olympic medal, c. 1,904 CE.

William DeHart Hubbard, the first Black American to win an individual Olympic gold medal, c. 1,924 CE.

Jesse Owens set three world records and won four Olympic gold medals, c. 1,936.

Alice Coachman Davis, the first Black woman to win an Olympic gold medal, c. 1,948 CE.

Wilma Rudolph shattered records, won three Olympic gold medals, and the *"Fastest Woman in the World"* title, c. 1,960 CE.

Ted Corbitt, the *"Father of Long-Distance Running,"* founder of the New York Road Runners, and the first Black American on the Olympic U.S. Marathon Team, c. 1,952 CE. Ted Corbitt, inducted into the National Distance Running Hall of Fame, c. 1,998 CE, and the American Ultrarunning Hall of Fame, c. 2,006 CE. New York City Parks named a six-mile stretch of Central Park the *"Ted Corbitt Loop."*

Boxing: Joe Gans/Joseph Gant *"Old Master,"* the first Black American lightweight boxing champion, c. 1,902–1,908 CE. The International Boxing Hall of Fame inducted Joe Gans, c. 1,990 CE.

Jack Johnson, the first Black American heavyweight boxing champion, c. 1,908-1,915 CE.

Joe Louis, *"The Brown Bomber,"* world heavyweight boxing champion, c. 1,937-1,949 CE.

Muhammad Ali, iconic world heavyweight boxing champion, activist, entertainer, and Olympic gold medalist, c. 1,960 CE.

Equestrian: Horse Racing: Black American jockeys—Isaac Burns Murphy, Oliver Lewis, Jimmy Winkfield, Willie Simms, Alonzo Clayton, ... dominated thoroughbred racing c. 1800 CE. After glorifying the sport, Black riders, trainers, and groomers experienced violence and Jim Crow laws. Oliver Lewis won the first Kentucky Derby aboard Aristides, c. 1,875 CE. Hall of Fame jockey Isaac Burns Murphy won the Kentucky Derby three times.

Cycling: Marshall Walter *"Major"* Taylor, *"The Black Cyclone,"* world champion cyclist, c. 1,901-1,909 CE.

Baseball: William Edward White, Moses Fleetwood Walker, and Weldy Wilberforce Walker, the first Black Americans to play in Major League Baseball, c. 1,879-1,884 CE.

Jackie Robinson, Leroy Robert "*Satchel*" Paige, and Willie Mays... reigned in the Negro Leagues, c. 1,920-1,940 CE, and champions in Major League Baseball.

Football: Fritz Pollard and Robert Wells Marshall, the first two Black Americans in the National Football League, c. 1,920 CE.

Hockey: Free Blacks from the United States of America founded Canada's Colored Hockey League of the Maritimes, c. 1,895 CE.

Tennis: Lucy Diggs Slowe, the first Black American woman to win the American Tennis Association's first tournament, c. 1,917 CE.

Ora Washington, a professional tennis and basketball player, won eight national singles titles, twelve national doubles titles, and three mixed doubles titles. The Women's Basketball Hall of Fame, c. 2,009 CE, inducted Ora Washington.

Althea Gibson won eleven grand slam tournaments and ranked "*Top Ten*," c. 1,951-1,958 CE. The International Tennis Hall of Fame, c. 1,971 CE, and the International Women's Sports Hall of Fame, c. 1,980 CE, inducted Althea Gibson.

Arthur Ashe won three grand slam tournaments and ranked "*Number One*," c. 1,970-1,980 CE.

Venus Williams won forty nine singles and twenty two doubles titles. Serena Williams won twenty three Grand Slam singles, fourteen doubles, and two mixed doubles titles with the Women's Tennis Association, c. 1,995-2,022 CE.

Basketball: The Harlem Globetrotters, the New York Rens... formed a Black independent basketball team in the "*Black Fives Era*," c. 1,904-1,950 CE.

Ora Washington, a twelve-year American Tennis Association champion, c. 1,929-1,937 CE, inducted into the Naismith Memorial Basketball Hall of Fame, c. 2,018 CE, and the Women's Basketball Hall of Fame, c. 2,009 CE.

Don Barksdale, the first Black American to medal in Olympic basketball, c. 1,948 CE.

Earl Lloyd, Charles Henry Cooper, and Nat "*Sweetwater*" Clifton, the first Black NBA players, c. 1,950 CE.

Harold Hunter, the first Black basketball player to sign an NBA contract and coach the US Olympic team. The first Black American NBA superstars, Wilt Chamberlain, Oscar Robinson, and Bill Russell.

Golf: John Shippen, the first Black professional golfer, c. 1,896 CE.

Dewey Brown, the first Black member of the PGA Professional Golfers 'Association, c. 1,928 CE.

Charlie Sifford, the first Black golfer to play in the Professional Golfers Association/PGA, c. 1,961 CE.

Joe Louis, the heavyweight boxing champion, fought for diversity in golf.

Althea Gibson, the first Black American to compete on the Women's Professional Golf Tour, c. 1,967 CE.

Lacrosse: Lucien Alexis Jr., the first Black collegiate lacrosse player, c. 1,940 CE.

Tina Sloan Green, the first Black player in the United States Women's National Field Hockey Team, the United States Women's National Lacrosse Team, c. 1,969 CE, and inducted into the US National Lacrosse Hall of Fame, c. 1,997 CE, the International Women's Sports Hall of Fame, c. 1,999 CE, and the Philadelphia Sports Hall of Fame, c. 2,013 CE.

Jim Brown, NFL and lacrosse champion, the first Black American in the National Lacrosse Hall of Fame, c. 1,983 CE.

Cherie Greer Brown, three-time World Champion, All-American, Olympic gold medalist, and in the National Lacrosse Hall of Fame, 2,009.

Soccer: Briana Scurry, a World Cup champion, Olympic gold medalist, United States Women's National Soccer team member, c. 1,994-2,008 CE, and the first Black American in the National Soccer Hall of Fame, c. 2,017 CE.

Beach Volleyball: Dain Blanton, the first Black American to win an Olympic gold medal in beach volleyball, c. 2,000 CE.

Water Polo: Genai Kerr, the first Black man to compete in the U.S. Water Polo World Championship, Olympian, mentor, and coach, c. 1,998-2,010 CE.

Bobsledding: Vonetta Flowers, the first Black American athlete to win a gold medal at the Winter Olympics, c. 2,002 CE.

Ice Skating and Speed Skating: Debi Thomas, World Champion Figure Skater, c. 1,986 CE, and the first Black Winter Olympics medalist in figure skating, c. 1,988 CE. Shani Davis, the first Black Olympic gold medalist, c. 2,006 CE in an individual speed skating event.

Fishing: Alfred Williams, the first Black fisher sponsored by Ranger Boats, c. 1,988-2,003 CE, and champion fisherman touring with Bassmaster, FLW...

Paralympic: Bonnie St. John, the first Black American to medal at the Paralympic Winter Games, c. 1,984 CE.

Decathlon: Milt Campbell, the first Black decathlon champion, Olympic silver medalist, c. 1,952 CE, and gold medalist, c. 1,956 CE.

Wrestling: Lloyd “Butch” Keaser, the first Black American to win an Olympic gold medal in a World Wrestling Championship, c. 1,973 CE.

Weightlifting: John Davis, the first Black weightlifter to medal in the Olympics, 1,948 and 1,952, undefeated 8-time world champion across three decades, c. 1938-1953 CE, and inducted into the United States Olympic and Paralympic Hall of Fame.

Martial Arts: Vic Moore, Jim Kelly, Moses Powell, Ron van Clief, Thomas “LaPuppet” Carroll, and Warren Lewis—Black championship martial artist, c. 1,970 CE.

Fencing: Peter Westbrook, the first Black fencer to win a national title and a U.S. Olympic gold medal, c. 1,983 CE.

Archery: Dallas Jones, the first Black U.S. Archery Champion, c. 2,017 CE.

Mountaineering and Exploring: Matthew Henson, the first recorded Black explorer to reach the North Pole, c. 1,909 CE.

Barbara Hillary, the first Black mountaineer to visit the North and South Poles, c. 2,007-2,011 CE.

Sophia Danenberg, the first Black mountaineer to climb to the summit of Mount Everest, c. 2,006 CE.

Teddy Seymour, the first Black American to sail around the world, c. 1,987 CE.

Kai Lightner, an award-winning professional rock climber and pioneer.

Woni Spotts, the first Black woman explorer to venture to every country and continent, c. 2,018 CE.

Motorsports/Nascar: Wendell Oliver Scott, the first Black racer to win a race in the Grand National Series and the inspiration for the film *"Greased Lightning."* The International Motorsports Hall of Fame, c. 1,999 CE, and the NASCAR Hall of Fame, c. 2,015 CE, inducted Wendell Oliver Scott.

Gymnastics: Dominique Margaux Dawes, the first Black gymnast to win an individual medal, Olympic gold medalist, c. 1,996 CE, three-time Olympian, and 10-year National Gymnastics team member. Dawes paved the way for future Olympians, gold medalists, and Team USA champions—Gabby Douglas, Simone Biles...

Ballet: Janet Collins, the first Black Prima Ballerina.

Alvin Ailey, award-winning choreographer, 1,953-1,989 CE.

Raven Wilkinson, the first Black dancer with a major ballet company, c. 1,955 CE.

Debra Austin, the first Black principal dancer with a major ballet company, c. 1,971-1,990 CE.

Misty Copeland, the first Black principal dancer in American Ballet Theater's 75-year history, c. 2,015 CE.

Cheerleading: Impact Xtreme, the first Black squad to win a national championship title, c. 2,021 CE.

Bodybuilding: Leroy Colbert's 21-inch biceps bulged from strength magazine covers, c. 1,950-1,960 CE.

Ronnie *"The King"* Coleman, the first Black bodybuilder to win eight consecutive Mr. Olympia competitions, c. 1,998-2,005 CE, and inducted into the International Sports Hall of Fame, c. 2,016 CE.

Skateboarding: Marty and Clyde Grimes, the first Black pro skateboarders, c. 1,975 CE.

Roller Skating/Derby: Darlene Anderson, the first Black professional roller derby skater, c. 1,958 CE.

Double Dutch Jump Rope: Black teams dominated the American Double Dutch League Championships since the founding in c. 1,974 CE.

Chess: Emory Andrew Tate Jr., a Black five-time chess champion in the Armed Forces and an International Master of Chess, c. 1,990-2,000 CE.

Checkers: Carl Sylvester “Buster” Smith, an eleven-time, Top Master in the American Pool Checkers Association Division Championship, c. 1,967 CE.

Billiards: Cisero Murphy, the first Black American to win national and world billiards titles. The Billiard Congress of America Hall of Fame inducted Cisero Murphy, c. 1,995 CE.

Poker: Phil Ivey, Poker Player of the Year, won the World Poker tour, and the first Black inductee in the Poker Hall of Fame, c. 2,017 CE.

Dominoes: Jerome Wooten, a Black multi-tournament world champion, c. 2,009-2,024 CE, and ranked best in the world by the Professional Domino Association.

Monopoly: Brian Valentine, a United States Monopoly Representative. Valentine competed at the World Championship in Macau, c. 2,015 CE.

Swimming: Cullen Jones, an Olympic gold medalist, c. 2,008 CE, and c. 2,012 CE, Olympic silver medalist, c. 2,007 CE, and c. 2,012 CE, and the first Black swimmer to hold a world record.

Surfing: Nick Gabaldon, surfed on California’s segregated beaches, c. 1,940-1,950 CE. Surf champion, Montgomery “Buttons” Kaluhiokalani created switch foot surfing, c. 1,970-1,996 CE. Larry “Rubberman” Bertlemann, surf champion, developed “Bert” footwork on surf and skateboards, c. 1,970-2,012 CE.

Equestrian: Polo, the Sport of Kings: National Champions “Work to Ride” Black Polo Team, c. 2,011 CE.

Rodeo: Cowboys herd animals, rope calves, ride bulls/broncs, and wrestle steers. Black American Hall of Fame inductees and rodeo stars—Bass Reeves, Stagecoach Mary Fields, George McJunkin, John Ware, Bose Ikard, Nat Love, Bill Pickett, Myrtis Dightman, Freddie “Skeet” Gordon, Willie Thomas, Harold Cash, Glynn Turman, and Tex Williams.

Bowling: George Branham III, the first Black Professional Bowlers Association/PBA national and world champion, c. 1,993 CE.

Academic Competitions: Black Americans, champions in spelling, science, math, debating... Marie C. Bolden, National Education Association Spelling Bee Champion in the first United States of America national contest, c. 1,908 CE.

Awards: Black American awards: Oscars, Grammys, Emmys, Tonys, Golden Globes, Beauty Pageants, Nobel Peace Prizes, Military Honors, and awards in Dancing, Choreography, Art, Literature, Teaching, and Humanitarianism, c. 1,890 CE-present-day.

Aviation: Bessie Coleman, the first Black American woman to hold a pilot's license, c. 1,921 CE. The Aviation Hall of Fame inductee inspired scholarships and a minted U.S. coin. Klerksdorp, South Africa, and Chicago, Dallas, Waxahachie, and Atlanta, in the United States of America, named streets in honor of the pilot.

Eugene James/ Jacques Bullard, "*Black Swallow of Harlem*," the first Black combat pilot, c. 1,917 CE. Though racially banned from U.S. military service, the aviator served the French in World War I with the French Foreign Legion and in World War II as a French resistance spy. The pilot opened a Parisian nightclub in France and internationalized the Harlem Renaissance. Posthumously, the U.S. Air Force awarded Eugene James/ Jacques Bullard with the Distinguished Flying Cross, medals, memorials, and dedications.

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